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BENUE BREAST CANCER SUPPORT INITIATIVE (BBCSI)

“Empowering Women. Saving Lives.”

BBCSI is dedicated to breaking the silence around breast cancer and supporting women across Benue State with advocacy and awareness.

☐ **Donate Now (link to Donations page)**

About Us

In many Benue communities, women face fear and stigma after a breast cancer diagnosis. Many believe cancer is a death sentence, and worse still, treatment costs are out of the reach of most. BBCSI stands with every woman in Benue who must fight cancer. We offer education, support, and practical help so that no woman fights alone. Together, we can replace myths with understanding, and secrecy with strength.

Too often, a diagnosis is hidden for fear of gossip, discrimination, or beliefs that cancer is caused by **witchcraft or spiritual attacks**.

We bring **truth, hope, and help** while educating families, encouraging early detection, and providing financial support to members for treatment.

We strive to empower women to speak openly about breast cancer, seek care early, and live healthy, fulfilling lives.

The mission of the **Benue Breast Cancer Support Initiative (BBCSI)** is to dismantle the culture of secrecy and silence surrounding breast cancer among women of African descent.

Our mission is to engage in **grassroots advocacy**, encourage regular **breast self-exams**, and offer **long-term treatment loans** to members actively undergoing care.

By combining advocacy, education, community outreach, and financial assistance, we give women the knowledge and resources they need to detect breast cancer early and access life-saving treatment. Read more about our history in our blog.

Meet our Team: (Add photos)

Chairperson

Secretary

Assistant Secretary

Treasurer

Financial Secretary

Zone C Coordinator

Nonprofit Ambassador

What We Do

Since its inception, BBCSI has organized in-person awareness campaigns every October in different local governments of Benue State. The COVID-19 pandemic caused us to move our campaigns online for two years. To date, our programs include:

1. **Support Group**

   A safe, welcoming space for women living with breast cancer,

survivors, and their families to share experiences, receive emotional support, and find strength together.

2. **Awareness Campaigns**

   Church and school visits, market outreaches, radio talks, and community events that spread information on early detection and breast self-examination.

3. **School & Church Outreach**

   Interactive sessions with students and faith-based groups to promote breast health education and encourage a culture of early screening.

4. **Long-Term Treatment Loans**

   Low-interest loans for BBCSI members currently undergoing treatment, easing the financial burden of care.

5. **Community Partnerships**

   Collaboration with hospitals, local leaders, and other nonprofits to expand screening access and strengthen support networks.

We envision a future where **every woman knows her body, speaks openly about breast health, and receives timely, affordable treatment.**

Get Involved

For Patients & Survivors

You are not alone. Join our support group and find encouragement, resources, and hope. To join, email us @Benuecancergroup@gmail.com

For Caregivers

Learn how to provide compassionate care while also caring for yourself. Visit our website often for tips and valuable resources.

For Donors & Partners

Your support helps educate communities, challenge dangerous myths, and provide treatment assistance. Every contribution saves lives. Donate Now!

For Policymakers & Health Professionals

Collaborate with us to strengthen cancer care systems and reduce stigma across Benue State.

Your involvement, no matter how small, helps save lives.

When we replace fear with facts, we save lives.

- "From Silence to Strength: Empowering Benue Women Against Breast Cancer."
- "Breaking Myths, Building Hope."

Breast Cancer: Facts vs. Myths

Myth	Fact
"Breast cancer is caused by witchcraft or a spiritual attack."	Breast cancer begins when normal cells in the breast grow uncontrollably. It is a **medical condition**, not a spiritual curse. Early detection and proper treatment save lives.

Myth	Fact
"Talking about breast cancer brings bad luck."	Open conversations help women detect cancer early and get treatment. **Silence puts lives at risk.**
"Only older women get breast cancer."	While risk increases with age, **younger women can also develop breast cancer.** Everyone should know how to check their breasts.
"A painless lump can't be dangerous."	Many breast cancers **do not cause pain** in the early stages. Any new lump or change should be checked by a health professional.
"Traditional herbs or prayer alone can cure breast cancer."	Faith and traditional remedies can bring comfort, but **medical treatment—such as surgery, chemotherapy, or radiotherapy—is what stops cancer from spreading.**

Key Message: *Breast cancer is not a curse. It is a disease we can fight together with knowledge, early detection, and proper care.*

❓ Frequently Asked Questions

1. How can I check my breasts at home?
Do a **monthly breast self-exam**: feel for lumps or changes in size, shape, or skin texture. BBCSI offers easy step-by-step guides and demonstrations.

2. When should I start screening?
Women from age **20** should perform monthly self-exams and get a **clinical breast exam every 1–3 years**. From age **40**, schedule a **mammogram every year** if available.

3. What should I do if I find a lump?
Don't panic and **don't hide it**. Visit a health facility or one of our partner clinics for evaluation as soon as possible.

4. Is breast cancer always fatal?
No. **Early detection saves lives.** When found early, breast cancer is highly treatable and many women live long, healthy lives.

5. How does BBCSI help?
We provide **support groups**, **awareness education**, **school and church outreach**, and **long-term treatment loans** for members undergoing care.

Blog

Insert Founder Photo

Prof. (Emerita) Stevina Evuleocha-Ugbah is a retired Professor of Marketing & Entrepreneurship of the California State University, East Bay, Hayward California. A breast cancer survivor herself, Stevina vowed to make a difference after receiving a $38,000 bill for her radiation treatment in 2013 and noticing in the payment window that she only needed to pay $15 because her health insurance covered the balance. When an opportunity presented itself three years post diagnosis to journey back to Benue State, Nigeria for a medical mission, Stevina knew instinctively that she would go to find women who have had a breast cancer experience. Setting up an initial support group of 12 women in 2016, Stevina tasked the women to go forth and bring the good news to other survivors that breast cancer is not a death sentence. Nine years later, that initial support group of 12 women has become the Benue Breast Cancer Support Initiative.

Relevant Breast Cancer Statistics

Globally, despite having a 5% lower breast cancer incidence rate than white women, Black women have a 38% higher mortality rate according to the American Cancer Society's 2024-2025 Breast Cancer Facts and Figures report. Among other factors, poverty, access to health care and other socio-economic and cultural factors contribute to disparities in survival rates. Additionally, black women are diagnosed with breast cancer at a later stage and tend to have a higher incidence of triple-negative breast cancer, a very aggressive form of breast cancer which is a lot more challenging to treat.

According to the World Health Organization, breast cancer is projected to double in prevalence by 2050 even as incidence rates rise across the region. Death rates will remain high with some countries experiencing over 200% increase in mortality rates. Early and improved screening as comprehensive management can lead to improved outcomes.

Considering these projections, BBCSI is committed to educating girls and women to prevent and survive cancer as well as drive home the message of “early detection saves lives!”



BBCSI History

What is now known as the Benue Breast Cancer Support Initiative (BBCSI) originally began in June 2016 because of the convergence of the following factors:

- The adjustment to the calendar for the Annual Health Fair organized by the Mutual Union of Tiv in America (MUTA) under the auspices of President Joseph Doo Gar. This adjustment made it possible for our founder Professor (Emerita) Stevina Evuleocha-Ugbah in the company of her daughter Teni Ugbah to participate in the 2016 MUTA Health Fair during which the idea of a breast cancer support group emerged.
- Mrs. Ngomon Gar's diligence in assisting with the location of breast cancer survivors-twelve of whom showed up on the last day of the fair.

- The generous donation of prosthetics, bras and camisoles by Mrs. Jennifer Milne, Co-Owner of Marzel's in Pleasanton, CA USA. Marzel's specializes in breast health care and prosthetics.

Three years post diagnosis, Stevina sought an outlet to use her breast cancer journey to make a difference. Unsure how to go about it, a request to edit a fundraising letter for the MUTA Health Fair in 2016 presented an opportunity to ask if the calendar could be adjusted to accommodate MUTA members who were educators in a quarter system. Once that calendar adjustment was made, a phone call to Marzel's yielded a suitcase full of prosthetics, bras and camisoles which were distributed at the first meeting during the fair. At that meeting 12 breast cancer survivors showed up in the company of Mrs. Hannah Tiohn.

We agreed to start a support group to check in on each other and begin awareness campaigns every October. We adopted Benue Breast Cancer Survivors Support Group (BBCSG) as our name, and designated 3 positions of Chairperson, Secretary and Treasurer. Our first campaign was in Gboko in 2016. We maintained this routine until the COVID-19 pandemic changed everything. We owe a debt of gratitude to Professor David Iornem, Trustee and Friend of BBCSI for taking it upon himself to advertise our activities in The New Times (TNT) newspaper while Hon. Kohol Iornem helped arrange for our jingles.

We moved our campaign online in 2020 & 2021 and invited Hon. Kohol Iornem (our moderator & partner for Life) on board. It was also in 2020 that BBCSI began a micro

loan program funded with the founder's birthday donations to assist members with cottage business or emergency financial needs.

In 2023, 2 major developments affected our operation. We registered as a nonprofit and our name became Benue Breast Cancer Support Initiative (BBCSI). One of our members in need of cancer treatment approached us for financial assistance. In that moment the idea of a long-term loan program for cancer treatment was born. Subsequently, it became clear that our members were most in need of assistance for treatment and did not borrow as much from the micro loan program. As of June 2025, we have transferred funds from the micro loan program to the long-term loan program.

Sadly, some of our members who fought gallantly have lost their fights in the time since we have been in operation. From 2016 to present, we have lost 20 brave warriors:

BBCSI Requiem

1.Mrs Akpereshi 2. Mrs Agirigi 3. Mrs F. Akume 4. Mrs M. Anyia 5. Mrs E. Adagi 6. Mrs M. Ajegba 7. Miss L. Okpanachi 8. Mrs H. Ekedegba 9. Mrs J. Ijih 10. Mrs P. Iorfa 11. Mrs N. Tsegba 12. Mrs C. Akumba 13. Mrs D. Zwawua 14. Mrs N. Orhemba 15. Mrs Naomi Gundu 16. Mrs. Miriam Dagba 17. Mrs. Iveren Terzungwe 2024 18. Mrs. Vera Oko - Asst. Secretary 19. Mrs. Dorcas Terwase 20. Mama Ayua

May our sisters souls and that of all the faithful departed Rest In Peace! We will always remember our fallen sisters.